

Lumber Estimating App Recommendations

Core Philosophy

Design the application around how framers think, not around how estimating software works. The goal should be to produce accurate takeoffs with the fewest possible clicks.

1. Draw First, Configure Later

Let users immediately draw walls and choose assemblies afterward with smart defaults.

2. Smart Defaults

Project settings should automatically determine wall assemblies, stud spacing, plate configuration, and material selections.

3. Simplified Toolbar

Reduce the interface to a handful of primary tools: Wall, Opening, Floor, Roof, Beam, Notes, Measure.

4. Keyboard Shortcuts

Support power users with shortcuts (W, O, F, R, Delete, Enter, Esc, Space).

5. Persistent Draw Mode

Remain in the active drawing tool until the user exits it.

6. Predict User Intent

Continue drawing similar wall types automatically.

7. Automatic Corners

Automatically generate corner framing based on selected framing standards.

8. Live Material Totals

Continuously update lumber counts while drawing.

9. Floating Material HUD

Display editable wall properties beside the cursor instead of requiring side panels.

10. Right-Click Context Menus

Place all common editing functions directly under the cursor.

11. Automatic Plan Recognition

Detect walls, openings, garages, decks, and porches from imported plans.

12. Favorite Assemblies

Allow users to create reusable wall assembly presets.

13. Apply to Similar

Update all matching walls with one command.

14. Live Editing

Stretch, shorten, and modify walls using draggable grips with instant recalculation.

15. Automatic Joining

Snap nearby walls together and update framing automatically.

16. AI Assistant

Offer intelligent framing suggestions based on detected building features.

17. Command Palette

Provide a searchable command interface similar to VS Code.

18. Reduce Settings

Move most configuration into Project Setup and inherit defaults elsewhere.

19. Visual Estimate Dashboard

Display material totals as clickable summary cards that highlight associated model elements.

20. Confidence Indicators

Show whether each wall is complete or missing information.

Flagship Feature

Implement a Sketch Mode where users roughly sketch floor plans and the software converts them into framed wall assemblies automatically.

Overall Vision

The winning product minimizes clicks, updates estimates in real time, and makes professional estimating feel effortless.